

That doesn't happen here unfortunately, for example, Bayonetta, which released in January 2010, is still selling here at full release price. In comparison, shopto.co.uk has a 70% discount on the same game.

This is just one of many old games that keep rotting in shelves because prices don't go down for them unless they're inducted into some kind of Classics or Platinum catalogue.

What's that?

Even when prices do go down for games, the staff at retail stores that sell those games don't bother keeping up to date with the prices and thus try to sell them off at the original prices.

Things would go a long way if the personnel at these places did some research, or kept themselves up to track with what was going on in the gaming world.

Sorry, not available

The perfect counter to the aforementioned problem would be specialised gaming retail outlets, a la Gamestop. There are a few around, like Game4U, Games – The Shop and Intencity, but they are extremely limited in number. It is our belief that people would be a lot more receptive to buying games if they knew they could go to a place where the catalogue and staff would be well updated and informed.

Gotcha... muhahahahaha

With all these problems plaguing retail, most gamers go online looking for a solution. There are quite a few web sites that sell games and ship them to customers, often offering a decent discount too. That has changed recently though, because a certain game distributor has issued a blanket ban on online retailers offering discounts on new games in a move that reeks of preferential treatment to its own retail arm.

WHY BEING AN INDIAN GAMER ROCKS

Most aspects of being an Indian gamer do suck, but it's not all doom and gloom. We have access to most consoles and PC components, and most games release here on time, something unthinkable a few years ago. It might not be as good as it is in the US or UK, but we're pretty well off when compared to most of the world.

While this may sound contradictory to something we said earlier, the fact that most games have subsidised prices for India can't be a bad thing. Sure, there are a few rotten apple

publishers who don't subsidise, the subsidies on the whole aren't quite enough and games are still expensive, but we'd rather have the subsidies than not. Don't you agree?

PC games though, are a completely different matter altogether. Indian prices for PC games are ridiculously low when compared to most other places, especially the US and UK. Look at the difference between a game's price on Steam, for example, and how much it costs to buy a retail disc here – it will make for one gamer who's happy to be Indian.

Spoilt brats

All of the above problems might seem a bit first-world to our brethren residing in non-metro locations, because gaming penetration, be it hardware or software, is pretty awful in that regard. There are hardly any places that stock legit games, and even if they do, the catalogue is not usually up-to-date.

So sloooooooooow

Let's face it, broadband in India sucks. The speeds are terrible, the plans are terrible and worst of all for gamers, the pings are terrible. If someone wants to go online for some multiplayer action, they're hit with copious amounts of lag. Dedicated servers for most games are conspicuous in their absence, which means we're forced to look at Singapore or other South-East Asian servers, which are not really the best of experiences thanks to the awful pings. Like one of the TDF members said, it would be nice if we could play online without having to worry about getting kicked from servers due to high pings.



Tch, tch...

By far the biggest problem though is the social outlook on gaming. In India, gaming is still considered a kid's activity, and most of us adult gamers are looked at like we're some strange extra-terrestrial specimen. Spending money on games is ridiculed, and our families balk at the amounts we spend to buy gaming consoles and the like.

Some gamers are guilty of this, too. They don't look past the Grand Theft Autos (Hot Coffee enabled, of course) or the Need for Speeds to see the massive library of entertainment that those games are but a tiny, tiny section of. **d**



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